MUSIC ▼

ON A HIGH

Playback and pop singer MADHUBANTI BAGCHI is a rising star of the Hindi film music industry



The electro-ghazal, *AAJ KI RAAT*, put singer Madhubanti Bagchi on the music map

"My general approach in life is 'Let's give it a shot'," says Madhubanti Bagchi. That attitude has served the playback and pop singer well. It's what led to her joining a wedding band while in engineering college in Kolkata; saying yes to an offer to sing for Bengali films—among her biggest hits is the Arijit Singh-duet 'Egiye De' from *Shudhu Tomari Jonyo* (2015)—and deciding to shift base to Mumbai in 2018 for "better opportunities".

Those risks are paying off. Today, Bagchi is a rising star of the Hindi film music industry. Over the past few months, she has been behind two huge Bollywood tracks, Sachin-Jigar's 'Aaj Ki Raat' from *Stree 2* (2024) and Amit Trivedi's 'Uyi Amma' from *Azad* (2025), and impressed listeners with her contributions to the soundtracks of the web series *Heeramandi* (2024) and *Panchayat* (2020). But it's the electro-ghazal 'Aaj Ki Raat' that has made her a name everyone's noticing.

It's significant that she's the main vocalist on the chart-topper, a rare occurrence for a female artist in an industry where, typically, men sing almost all the songs in a movie, even those centred on women characters. The times are a changing, believes Bagchi. "It's about ear fatigue," she says. "If you keep hearing the same voices for a long time—it could be mine too in a couple of years—you automatically want to hear something new."

She also feels that the current crop of hit-making female singers—a list that includes Shilpa Rao and Parampara Thakur, apart from herself—don't have the saccharine-sounding tone that dominated the decades gone by. "It's more bold and in-your-face," she says. "This has happened with the evolution of women and their position in our country. Even if you look at female actors, very few



SABR has 12 tracks and some 50 vocalists and guest artistes collaborating

SOUNDS OF FUSION

The Anirudh Varma Collective's third studio album, *Sabr*, offers a captivating fusion of classical and contemporary music

Featuring a diverse array of 50 vocalists and guest artistes from across India, *Sabr*, the new 12-track record of the Anirudh Varma Collective (AVC) blends Indian classical with jazz, folk and global music as well as pieces inspired by the poet Kabir. Creating a genre-fluid, immersive experience, the album encapsulates themes